What Happens After the Hospital?

A short guide to care needs, levels of care and the questions behind them.

People at the hospital keep saying “level of care” as if you already knew what it meant. Meanwhile discharge is being discussed, somebody mentioned Medicare, and everyone is asking you what happens next.

This guide explains, in general terms, what those conversations are about, so you can follow them and ask better questions. It explains. It doesn't say what Mom needs, where she should go, or what anything will cost.

Where things stand right now

The conversation you've been pulled into has a name. The Family Caregiver Alliance, citing Medicare, describes discharge planning as a process that determines the kind of care a patient needs after leaving the hospital. Some hospitals have a dedicated discharge planner. Your point person could also be a social worker, a nurse or another member of staff. [1]

Families have a place in it. In a skilled nursing facility, Medicare.gov says, a team from different medical fields plans the care, and the patient, the family or someone acting on the patient's behalf can help plan it. It suggests letting the staff know you want to be involved. [2]

- Write down what changed, in order, and who told you each part.
- Write down each date you've been given, and whether it was confirmed or only mentioned.

What “care needs” means

“Care needs” covers more than medicine. Most long-term care, the federal Administration for Community Living says, is not medical care. It is help with the basic personal tasks of everyday life, sometimes called activities of daily living, or ADLs: bathing, dressing, using the toilet, moving to or from a bed or chair, caring for incontinence, and eating. [3]

A second group, sometimes called instrumental activities of daily living, covers everyday tasks such as housework, managing money, taking medication, preparing meals, shopping and using the telephone. [3]

- For each activity, the useful note is what you've seen Mom do on her own this week, where someone helps, and what you haven't seen.
- That is a description. How much help she needs, and how much supervision, is for the people who assess her.

What “level of care” means

The public sources we checked don't define the phrase. People generally use it for how much help someone needs, what kind, and where it can be given. Long-term care can be provided at home, in the community, or in a facility. Most of it is provided at home, by family members and friends, or by a nurse, a home health or home care aide, or a therapist who comes to the home. [3] [4]

Assisted living, as MedlinePlus describes it, is housing and services for people who need some help with daily care, such as dressing, bathing and taking their medicines, but who do not need the medical care that a nursing home provides. Its residents are usually older adults, including people with Alzheimer's or other types of dementia. You may also hear “memory care.” When you do, ask what it includes at that place. [5]

Nursing homes provide the most comprehensive range of services, including nursing care and 24-hour supervision. For many people, the Administration for Community Living notes, a blended approach works best. [4]

- Which of these fits Mom isn't something a guide can tell you. Ask the care team what help they expect her to need after she leaves, and where that help can be given.

Where Medicare, Medicaid and cost come in

Two words do a lot of work in these conversations. Medicare.gov describes skilled care as nursing and therapy care that can only be safely and effectively performed by, or under the supervision of, professionals or technical personnel. Long-term care, which it says is also called custodial care, is for people who need help with activities of daily living, like bathing, dressing or eating. [6] [7]

The distinction matters because the programs treat the two differently. In general terms, Medicare.gov says Medicare generally doesn't cover long-term nursing home stays unless a person is receiving skilled nursing care. Medicaid is a separate program, run jointly by the federal government and the states, and its eligibility rules and covered services vary from state to state. What either one means for Mom depends on her situation and her state, and this guide can't tell you. [7] [8]

Cost works the same way. The cost of long-term care depends on the type and duration of care, the provider and where you live, so the numbers that matter are the ones you get from the providers themselves. [9]

- Ask the staff whether the care Mom is getting now is skilled care, and how you would be told if that changes.
- Take coverage questions to the facility, to Mom's plan or to Medicare. If she has a Medicare Advantage Plan, Medicare.gov says to check with the plan.
- Take questions about Medicaid to your Medicaid planner. The Administration for Community Living names each state's Medical Assistance office as the best source on how to qualify in that state.

What this means for your family

- “Level of care” becomes three plainer questions: what help does Mom need, what kind, and where can it be given?
- Your part is to describe what you've seen and to ask. The care team's part is to assess.
- Listen for the words “skilled” and “custodial,” and write down who used them and when.
- Where the honest answer is “it depends on the state and the situation,” the person to ask is the facility for coverage, the provider for cost, and your Medicaid planner for Medicaid.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what level of care Mom needs, whether she can go home, what Medicare or Medicaid will cover for her, or what her care will cost. The definitions and general statements come from the sources below. The advice about what to write down and ask is ours. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You can follow the conversation about care needs and levels of care now. The care interview asks about Mom's own situation one area at a time, so nothing important is overlooked, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
2. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Assessments & care plans in Skilled Nursing Facilities
3. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), What is Long-Term Care?
4. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Where Can You Receive Care?
5. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Assisted Living: MedlinePlus
6. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), SNF Care Coverage
7. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Nursing Home Coverage
8. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid
9. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Costs of Care